Aquifer Open Study Notes

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2 Chronicles

2 Chronicles 1:1

David asked the Lord to be with Solomon (1 Chronicles 22:11) and for Solomon to be strong and courageous (1 Chronicles 28:20). David also said God would make Solomon great and give strength to all Israel (1 Chronicles 29:12). Three points about Solomon reflect David's blessings:

1. Solomon took firm control of his kingdom
2. God was with him
3. God made him very powerful

2 Chronicles 1:2–6

Solomon's journey to Gibeon, as reported in 1 Kings 3:4, is explained in more detail here. This important public event was closely linked to Solomon becoming king. Military commanders and clan leaders attended the event. It happened in Gibeon because the tabernacle and the great bronze altar, where sacrifices were often made, were located there.

2 Chronicles 1:3

Tent: See study note on Exodus 27:21.

2 Chronicles 1:7–12

See "Solomon's Wisdom" Theme Note.

2 Chronicles 1:10

Solomon received wisdom and knowledge to govern well. The Hebrew word "shapat," often translated as "judge" (as in the Book of Judges), can also mean "govern."

2 Chronicles 1:14–17

The description of Solomon's wealth and power (detailed in 2 Chronicles 9:25–28) is based on the summary of his kingdom in 1 Kings 10:26–29. In Kings, this summary of Solomon's wealth led to the negative aspects of his rule (1 Kings 11). Here, Solomon's gathering of wealth demonstrated the fulfillment of God's promise (2 Chronicles 1:12).

2 Chronicles 1:16

If Egypt is the correct translation, this verse shows Solomon's disobedience (see Deuteronomy 17:16). However, importing from Muzur in Anatolia was allowed.

2 Chronicles 2:1

The temple is the first priority among Solomon's building projects, even though construction began in the fourth year of his reign (2 Chronicles 3:2). Solomon spent the earlier years negotiating with King Hiram (2 Chronicles 2:3) for materials and skilled workers.

2 Chronicles 2:5–6

The house...will be great: The temple's greatness and God's greatness are different. Even the highest heavens cannot contain God.

2 Chronicles 2:8

- The cedar, known as Cedrus libani or "cedar of Lebanon," is famous for its beauty, height (up to 100 feet), and fragrant wood. Kings from Egypt, Phoenicia, Assyria, Babylon, Persia, and Greece used cedar wood from Lebanon to build temples and palaces.
- Algum logs was used to make supports for the Temple, possibly pillars or railings, as well as musical instruments (see 1 Kings 10:11). Although often mentioned in ancient texts, the exact type of this hard, reddish-brown wood is unknown.

2 Chronicles 2:13–14

The temple needed the skill and knowledge of Huram-abi, a master craftsman. Huram-abi was an expert in metals like gold, silver, bronze, and iron, as well as stone, wood, and textiles such as purple, blue, and scarlet cloth and fine linen. Similarly, God chose Bezalel as the master craftsman of the tabernacle and gave him wisdom to complete the work (Exodus 31:1–5).

2 Chronicles 2:17–18

The book of Kings states that people from the seven nations were forced into labor. No Israelites were forced to work; instead, they supervised the laborers (1 Kings 9:20–23).

2 Chronicles 3:1

Kings focuses on when the temple was built, while Chronicles highlights the importance of its location. The temple stood in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, where the Lord appeared to David. David chose this sacred site, where a plague ended at Araunah the Jebusite's threshing floor. In the land of Moriah, Abraham bound Isaac (Genesis 22:2), and tradition links the Temple Mount to where the Lord provided for Abraham (Genesis 22:14).

2 Chronicles 3:1–4

In Chronicles, the temple is the main focus of Solomon's reign. However, it provides less detail about its architecture and furnishings than the book of Kings does (for example, 1 Kings 6:2–10).

2 Chronicles 3:2

The book of Kings dates the start of the temple construction by linking it to the exodus from Egypt (1 Kings 6:1). Chronicles often leaves out mentions of the exodus. This may highlight the ongoing and lasting connection between the people, the land, and God.

2 Chronicles 3:5–7

The inside of the temple was completed using expensive materials (see 1 Kings 6:15–18, 29).

2 Chronicles 3:6

The gold from Parvaim was of the highest quality. By the time of the earliest translators, the exact location of Parvaim was unknown. The Chronicler might not have known it either.

2 Chronicles 3:8

A special area called the most holy place was built deep inside the hall. It could have been a sacred throne space within the long hall or a separate room inside the main hall. The most holy place measured 9.1 meters (twenty cubits) in every direction. It might have been on a raised platform, similar to shrines in other temples, and there might have been space between the room and the roof. The most holy place was designed to hold the ark, which contained the covenant terms.

2 Chronicles 3:10–13

The figures shaped like cherubim were made of expensive wild olive wood and covered with gold. Similar carvings have been found in Mesopotamia, Syria, and Canaan. These figures were a key feature of ancient thrones. Cherubim were creatures that combined the symbolism for royalty (lion) with strength (bull), speed (eagle), and wisdom (human). Ancient temples in Phoenicia show the deity's throne supported by two animals. The sides of ancient Canaanite thrones were often shaped like cherubs. The cherubs in Solomon's temple were unique because they were not meant to serve as a human throne. They were attached to the ark, which was the footstool of God's throne. Their wings touched in the middle and extended to the walls of the throne room. There was no actual seat on the throne because none was needed.

2 Chronicles 3:15–16

The two pillars in the temple's porch were made of bronze and had elaborate decorations (compare 1 Kings 7:15–22).

2 Chronicles 3:17

Jakin, meaning "he establishes," might refer to God's promise about the kingdom (see 1 Chronicles 17:7–14). Boaz, meaning "in him is strength," might have been a statement of trust in God. The gilded reliefs of cherubs, palms, and flowers on the temple's doors and walls suggest that the pillars were connected to the tree of life (Genesis 2:9).

2 Chronicles 4:2–5

The temple, God's house, symbolized Eden, God's garden (see Isaiah 51:3). The large sea, supported by twelve bronze oxen, represented either the waters before creation or the life-giving waters from the Garden of Eden. Divine forces control the chaotic waters (Genesis 1:2) so they nourish plants, animals, and humans (see Revelation 21:1, where the sea is gone forever).

2 Chronicles 4:6

The sea had the same purpose as the bronze washbasin in the tabernacle (see Exodus 30:18–19).

2 Chronicles 4:7

The seven lights on each of the ten gold lampstands might have represented the Pleiades. This is a cluster of stars symbolized by seven dots in ancient Mesopotamia (compare Job 9:9; 38:31; Amos 5:8).

2 Chronicles 4:11–18

Compare 1 Kings 7:40b–47, which the Chronicler follows almost word for word.

2 Chronicles 4:19

The Bread of the Presence represented God's provision for his people. It was placed before God on the tables (2 Chronicles 4:8) as an offering, showing it belonged to God and that Israel's provision came from God's "table." The priests ate some of the bread (Leviticus 24:5–9), and the rest was burned. This meal symbolized the covenant meal of fellowship between God and his people (see Exodus 24:9–11).

2 Chronicles 5:1

- This verse ends the section about temple furnishings, closely following 1 Kings 7:51.

- the items his father David had dedicated: Just as the treasures taken from Egypt were used to build the tabernacle, the treasures from Israel's enemies were used to build the temple. The prophets often described the treasures of other nations as available for Israel's use (see Isaiah 60:10–14; Zechariah 14:14).

2 Chronicles 5:3

The dedication of the temple occurred during the annual Feast of Tabernacles, held in early autumn. This seven-day festival required a pilgrimage to the central place of worship (Deuteronomy 16:13–15). The seventh month marked the end of Israel's harvest season, allowing landowners to leave for a week without worrying about fields or crops.

2 Chronicles 5:5

The Tent of Meeting: The "Tent of Meeting" is a special tent mentioned in Exodus. It refers to the tabernacle's role (for example, Exodus 33:7). The tabernacle was where God's presence dwelled (for example, Exodus 25:8–9) and where God met with his people through the priests. After the temple was built, the tent was no longer needed.

2 Chronicles 5:7–8

The giant cherubim symbolized God's universal and eternal rule.

2 Chronicles 5:9

The Hebrew phrase to this day might mean from then on. The Ark was likely not in the temple after the exile in Babylon, when the Chronicler wrote.

2 Chronicles 5:10

The ark held only the tablets of the covenant (see Exodus 25:21; Deuteronomy 10:5). The pot of manna that Aaron placed in the ark (Exodus 16:33–34) was apparently lost.

2 Chronicles 5:11–14

The Chronicler describes the temple dedication with a detailed account of a grand celebration. He lists the three specific groups of singers and all their relatives. The 120 trumpeters likely included five priests from each of the 24 divisions (1 Chronicles 24:3–19). The sanctified priests wore their standard fine linen robes. The musical instruments, singers, and trumpeters were all in their proper places. When the priests left, the musicians began their song, and the cloud of the Lord's glorious presence filled the temple.

2 Chronicles 6:1–2

The dedication ceremony ended with Solomon's poetic speech about the temple's main idea. God chose to live in the thick cloud of darkness. The temple's dedication confirmed God's choice of Israel as his people and his ongoing presence among them.

2 Chronicles 6:4–6

Israel's history as God's people began with the exodus and peaked when God chose David as king and made Jerusalem his capital. Both the city and the dynasty were part of God's promise to David (see 1 Chronicles 28:4; compare 2 Samuel 7:8–17; Psalm 2:6–7).

2 Chronicles 6:10–11

The Chronicler combines the Sinai covenant, symbolized by the ark, with the Jerusalem temple and the Davidic dynasty. He does not mention Israel's exodus from Egypt, only hinting at it through the ark. Under Solomon and David, God's covenant with Israel shaped the community's relationship with God during the Chronicler's time.

2 Chronicles 6:18

even the highest heavens, cannot contain You: All creation is like God's true temple, the palace of the divine king (see Isaiah 66:1–2).

2 Chronicles 6:21–39

In his covenant with Israel, the Lord promised blessings and life for obedience, and curses and death for disobedience (Deuteronomy 27:11–28:68; 30:15–18). Solomon prayed for God to listen and forgive when the people broke God's covenant. The seven "if-then" requests in his prayer covered any future situations the covenant people might face. In each case, Solomon described the situation and asked God to help his people.

2 Chronicles 6:22–23

Petition 1: Solomon asked for justice when it is hard to determine guilt or innocence. For example, in a theft case (Exodus 22:7–9), both the plaintiff and the defendant would swear oaths before God. The guilty person would then pay double.

2 Chronicles 6:24–25

Petition 2: Solomon asked God to give relief when people repent after sin causes trouble. Prayer offers a chance for redemption, and God's people receive his forgiveness through restoration.

2 Chronicles 6:26–27

Petition 3: Solomon asked God to guide his people to follow the right path. He wanted to ensure that sin would not stop God's blessing of rain for the land.

2 Chronicles 6:28–31

Petition 4: Solomon showed a special sensitivity to human suffering. He included both the private sorrow of those whose pain is hidden and the public distress of those whose pain is obvious. The prayer is personal, asking for God's understanding of each person's motives. It also asks for God's guidance so that the pain of failure might encourage the individual to follow God's ways in the future.

2 Chronicles 6:32–33

Petition 5: Solomon showed concern for people from other nations who chose to join the covenant society after seeing God's blessings on those who obeyed it (Deuteronomy 4:6–8). Solomon prayed for mercy for these foreigners, just as he did for native Israelites.

2 Chronicles 6:34–35

Petition 6: Solomon asked God to listen to the people's prayers when they followed God's command to fight their enemies.

2 Chronicles 6:36–39

Petition 7: Solomon worried that Israel might be completely exiled, as shown in the last part of his prayer. Israel faced many exiles, but the total destruction of Jerusalem and its temple was the hardest test of faith. Solomon saw the temple as a source of faith; even in a foreign land, people could remember it and pray. Mentioning the land, city, and temple (2 Chronicles 6:38) suggests total destruction, not just partial exile. Even if the temple was gone, people could still pray to God in heaven, who would hear and forgive.

2 Chronicles 6:41–42

- Solomon's prayer ends with a quote from a psalm (Psalm 132:8–10). This prayer marked the final step in moving the ark to its place in the temple. Prayers with psalms also accompanied David's move of the ark to Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 16:7–36). Solomon's use of a psalm reminds us of when the ark first reached its rightful place.
- God is called to arise, not for war (compare Numbers 10:35), but to rest in the temple.

2 Chronicles 6:42

In line with the start of the prayer (2 Chronicles 6:15–17), Solomon asks God to remember his constant love for David. This refers to the covenant promise God made to David (1 Chronicles 17:4–14; see Isaiah 55:3).

2 Chronicles 7:1–3

When they brought the ark to its place (see 2 Chronicles 5:13–14), the glorious presence of the Lord descended on the temple. The divine glory stayed in the temple, stopping the priests from entering to perform their duties (see "The Glory of God" Theme Note and "God's Glory with His People" Theme Note).

2 Chronicles 7:4–6

Sacrifices were essential to dedicate the dwelling of the most high on earth. They also provided food for the people during the fifteen-day celebration. The number of animals sacrificed matches those in 1 Kings 8:63.

2 Chronicles 7:8–10

Lebo-hamath in the north and the Brook of Egypt in the south marked Israel's boundaries, as promised to the patriarchs (Genesis 15:18; Numbers 34:5, 8; Joshua 15:4). The temple dedication festival occurred before the annual Festival of Shelters, which ended on the twenty-second day of the month.

2 Chronicles 7:13–15

These verses refer directly to Solomon's prayer (see 2 Chronicles 6:26, 28, 40). God explained to Solomon what is needed to be saved from judgment. In Solomon's prayer, each situation was addressed separately. In the Lord's answer, the response is more general and thorough. The people need humility, repentance, seeking the Lord, and prayer to heal from their troubles.

2 Chronicles 7:17–18

God told Solomon that God's kingdom is eternal. In 1 Kings 9:5, it says one of Solomon's descendants will always be on Israel's throne. The Chronicler says one of Solomon's descendants will always rule Israel. During the Chronicler's time, there was no throne in Israel, so this refers to the Messiah (compare Micah 5:2).

2 Chronicles 7:19–22

Even though it was magnificent, people mocked the temple when the Israelites turned away from the Lord. The Babylonians destroyed the temple in 586 BC.

2 Chronicles 8:2

The twenty towns Solomon gave to Hiram in exchange for gold did not satisfy Hiram (1 Kings 9:11–14). This suggests Hiram returned them to Solomon, who likely offered something else in return.

2 Chronicles 8:3

This verse is the only mention in Chronicles of Solomon's military achievements; he was known as a man of peace (1 Chronicles 22:9). The kingdoms of David and Solomon reached Hamath-zobah in the far north on the Orontes River. King Toi, the ruler of Hamath, sought David's help against Hadadezer, the king of Zobah (1 Chronicles 18:9–10). Hadadezer was also called the king of Zobah-Hamath (1 Chronicles 18:3). Solomon led an expedition to this area to keep his kingdom's northern border stable.

2 Chronicles 8:4

The Chronicler talks about the northern parts of Solomon's kingdom. Tadmor, later known as Palmyra, was an oasis city in Syria on the desert trade routes with Mesopotamia, 120 miles northeast of Damascus. It is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible. Eventually, it was linked with the list of fortified cities in Solomon's kingdom (compare 1 Kings 9:18, where Tamar/Tadmor refers to a city in southeast Judah).

2 Chronicles 8:5

Upper and Lower Beth-horon are on a ridge that rises from the Valley of Aijalon to the plateau north of Jerusalem. Fortifications guarded the path linking Jerusalem to the main coastal trade route.

2 Chronicles 8:6

Some cities served as storage sites and for military cavalry. Large building complexes at Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer had long rooms divided into three sections with two rows of pillars. These rooms might have been used as stables and storehouses, or they might have served as barracks for a professional army.

2 Chronicles 8:11

Solomon's marriage to Pharaoh's daughter, an Egyptian alliance, is mentioned often in Kings (1 Kings 3:1; 9:16, 24; 11:1). This marriage shows Solomon's kingdom and international influence. He gave her a permanent home to show she was his most important wife. This also kept David's palace sacred, likely because Pharaoh's daughter followed a different religion.

2 Chronicles 8:17–18

The Chronicler highlights Solomon's activities at the northern and southern borders of his kingdom to show the size of his empire. Solomon controlled ports on the Red Sea, which enabled international trade to the south. Hiram was a valuable ally; his people, the Phoenicians of Tyre, had extensive trade networks and were expert sailors, helping Solomon trade with Ophir. Ophir is traditionally believed to be in southwest Arabia (see Genesis 10:28–29).

2 Chronicles 9:1–2

Solomon had long-term economic and political ties with Hiram of Tyre (2 Chronicles 8:17–18; 9:10–11), but the queen of Sheba visited only once. Ancient Sheba, roughly modern Yemen, was known for its female rulers and a wealthy economy based on trading frankincense and myrrh. An ancient tradition suggests the queen of Sheba came from Cush (Ethiopia), possibly due to Sheba, son of Raamah, a descendant of Cush (Genesis 10:7; 1 Chronicles 1:9).

2 Chronicles 9:3–4

The queen noticed the impressive splendor of Solomon's court, showcasing his wealth and wisdom.

2 Chronicles 9:9

- 120 talents: The queen gave Solomon gold equal to what he received from Hiram (see 1 Kings 9:14).
- The queen's gift of spices, such as frankincense and myrrh, were used in cosmetics, embalming, and religious offerings. High demand and repeated taxation along the long trade route made the spices as valuable as gold when given to a king (see Matthew 2:11). Solomon was so wealthy that the queen had to give an enormous gift for it to be significant.

2 Chronicles 9:13–14

The phrase "translated each year" can also mean one specific year. This makes it unclear if 25 tons referred to Solomon's yearly income or just his best year. Solomon also collected taxes from foreign traders and local merchants. The kings of Arabia were likely merchant leaders who used the routes from Edom to Damascus. The governors of the provinces were district officials.

2 Chronicles 9:15–16

In ancient Syria and Assyria, people often used ornamental and ceremonial shields. Large shields covered the whole body and might have had three sides. Small shields, worn on the arm, offered light protection.

Guards showed their shields when the king went to the temple.

2 Chronicles 9:17–19

Solomon's throne was very impressive. It had six steps, and the throne might have been on a platform that made a seventh step. Similar Babylonian temple towers had seven stages to symbolize the whole universe.

2 Chronicles 9:21

- Solomon's fleet of trading ships from Tarshish transported cargo. These strong ships had a unique shape that allowed them to sail long distances in the open sea.
- and peacocks: The meaning of the Hebrew word is unclear. Solomon was so influential that he imported fine goods and exotic animals from the farthest parts of the known world.

2 Chronicles 9:29

The Chronicler likely used collections of prophetic writings or historical records as sources. The works of individual prophets might have been included in larger collections. These sources are now lost. Nathan and Ahijah were active during the reigns of David and Solomon. Iddo is not well-known.

2 Chronicles 9:30

Solomon ruled from 971 to 931 BC.

2 Chronicles 10:1

- Shechem was in the center of the northern tribes' land. Rehoboam went there for confirmation, showing either weak national unity or the northern tribes' strength and influence.
- Rehoboam ruled from 931 to 913 BC.

2 Chronicles 10:2

Jeroboam...had fled from King Solomon: See 1 Kings 11:26–40. Jeroboam returned from Egypt when he heard about Solomon's death.

2 Chronicles 10:4

Rehoboam lacked the power to enforce taxes on the northern tribes, so they asked for concessions to stay under his rule.

2 Chronicles 10:6

The older men of Israel were different from officials, nobles, and guardians (Judges 8:14; 1 Kings 21:8; 2 Kings 10:5) who held government positions. These elders traditionally had significant influence on royal decisions. When Ben-hadad, king of Aram, attacked Samaria, the elders of Samaria firmly rejected his harsh surrender terms (1 Kings 20:7–9). Earlier, during Absalom's revolt against David, the elders of Israel played a key role in important decisions (2 Samuel 17:4, 15; 19:11).

2 Chronicles 10:8

Rehoboam was forty-one years old when he began to reign (2 Chronicles 12:13), so the young men who grew up with him were not beginners. They might have been royal princes, sons of Solomon's other wives. It was natural for them to have a role in Rehoboam's government, as shown by his promotion of his son Abijah (2 Chronicles 11:22). Calling these princes "young" might have been a comment on the value of their advice, because people did not consider the young to be wise (see Job 12:12).

2 Chronicles 10:10–11

The younger counselors' words matched Rehoboam's attitude. They lacked the elders' experience but shared Rehoboam's preferences. They used metaphors and rhetoric suited for a royal court.

2 Chronicles 10:16

The people replied with words opposite to a poetic saying the Chronicler used earlier (1 Chronicles 12:18). There, the people from the southern tribes of Benjamin and Judah (1 Chronicles 12:16) showed increasing support for David.

2 Chronicles 10:18

Rehoboam went to Shechem to become king but barely escaped with his life. He showed poor judgment by sending a civilian official, not a military leader, to enforce mandatory military service.

2 Chronicles 11:1–4

Shemaiah's prophecy stopped an immediate civil war among Israel's tribes. However, Rehoboam's reign is described as one of constant conflict with Jeroboam (2 Chronicles 12:15). Civil war marked the first fifty years of the divided kingdom, lasting until Omri's time.

2 Chronicles 11:5–12

Rehoboam fortified several towns to defend Judah from the east, south, and west. This protected the valleys leading into the Judean hill country and important crossroads. Rehoboam's first task was to strengthen a small but defensible position. The defensive lines

were strategically sensible against an Egyptian attack and likely started before Pharaoh Shishak's invasion in 926 or 925 BC.

2 Chronicles 11:5–23

The Lord blessed Rehoboam through his building projects, the movement of loyal priests from the north to the south, the migration of faithful people from the north to Jerusalem, and his large family.

2 Chronicles 11:9

Lachish was the key southwestern corner of Rehoboam's defenses. It protected the road to the coastal highway in the west, a main route Egypt could use for a southern attack.

2 Chronicles 11:13–17

Jeroboam's rebellion in the north (see 1 Kings 12:26–33) caused those who truly wanted to worship the Lord to move south. Rehoboam followed the Lord faithfully for three years, but he became unfaithful in the fourth year of his reign (2 Chronicles 12:1). God then quickly punished Rehoboam by sending Shishak to invade from Egypt (2 Chronicles 12:2–5).

2 Chronicles 11:15

Some scholars think Jeroboam set up goat and calf idols as platforms for the Lord. They note that the Canaanites believed their gods stood on animals (compare Exodus 32:5, where the gold calf was used in "a feast to the LORD"). However, Jeroboam never specifically credited the Lord with rescuing Israel (1 Kings 12:28), so others believe he might have meant other gods stood on the animals. Still others think Jeroboam might have copied the Egyptians, who showed pagan deities in animal form (compare Exodus 32:4).

2 Chronicles 11:18–22

Rehoboam likely had the same number of wives and children throughout his reign, not just by his fifth year. He loved his second wife more than his first, so he broke the rule of primogeniture (inheritance belonging to the firstborn son, Deuteronomy 21:15–17) by making Abijah the next king, possibly in a co-regency. This action ensured a smooth succession.

2 Chronicles 11:23

Rehoboam gave control to the royal princes, extending the royal family's rule into distant areas. This ensured a smooth power transition and reduced the chance of a revolt or coup. Rehoboam might have done this to avoid the troubles God promised David's house (2 Samuel 12:10–11).

2 Chronicles 12:1–2

The book of Kings does not give a religious reason for Egypt's invasion. However, the Chronicler explains that the Egyptians attacked Jerusalem because Rehoboam broke the covenant and defied the Lord.

2 Chronicles 12:2–4

Shishak, also called Shoshenq I, ruled a unified Egypt from 945 to 924 BC and started the 22nd dynasty.

2 Chronicles 12:3

- Sukkites are not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible. However, Egyptian history identifies them as Libyans from the western desert oases.
- Cushites: Shishak was an Ethiopian from southern Egypt.

2 Chronicles 12:6–7

Shemaiah's speech outlines the elements needed in Solomon's prayer during the temple's dedication (2 Chronicles 7:14). The leaders of Israel humbled themselves, and Jerusalem was spared from judgment.

2 Chronicles 12:9–11

Rehoboam faced punishment for his disobedience through the looting of the royal treasuries and the temple. The guard used to carry gold shields when accompanying the king from the palace to the temple. The royal processions lost much of their splendor when they replaced the gold shields with bronze ones (compare 2 Chronicles 9:15–16). These bronze shields were safely stored in the large armory Solomon had built (2 Chronicles 8:6).

2 Chronicles 12:12

When Rehoboam repented, God allowed good things to stay in Jerusalem:

- The people's repentance
- Their decision to seek the Lord
- The continuation of worship (see 2 Chronicles 19:3)

2 Chronicles 13:1

Abijah is called Abijam in Kings (for example, 1 Kings 15:1). Abijam, possibly the Canaanite version of his name, means "my father is Yam." Yam was the Canaanite sea god featured in the Baal stories (see study note on Job 7:12). Abijah means "my father is

Yah," the common short form for Yahweh, the God of Judah. Abijah ruled from 913 to 910 BC.

2 Chronicles 13:2–3

The conflict between Rehoboam and Jeroboam (see 2 Chronicles 12:15) continued into Abijah's reign. Abijah might have tried to reunite the north and south, as suggested by his speech (2 Chronicles 13:5–12). The large number of soldiers on each side is similar to David's census (2 Samuel 24:9). Israel's larger army highlights God's help for Judah (2 Chronicles 13:14–19).

2 Chronicles 13:4

Mount Zemaraim: This town was on the northern border of Benjamin (see Joshua 18:22), about five miles northeast of Bethel. Benjamin served as a buffer and battleground between the northern and southern kingdoms.

2 Chronicles 13:5

a covenant of salt: Salt was needed with a grain offering (Leviticus 2:13). The social and religious background for this phrase is unknown. However, salt was used to preserve food, making it a good metaphor for a permanent covenant.

2 Chronicles 13:6–7

Abijah's speech criticized the northerners for not supporting David's kingdom.

2 Chronicles 13:8–9

Abijah's speech highlighted two main points about the northern rebellion: The north rejected:

1. The rightful king
2. The true place of worship

The northerners' revolt, where they expelled the proper priestly order, contrasts sharply with us (2 Chronicles 13:10). The most objectionable issues were the worship of the calves and the role of unauthorized priests.

2 Chronicles 13:10–11

Abijah's speech shows he cares about keeping worship pure in Jerusalem. The account in Kings does not mention Abijah's devotion (1 Kings 15:3–4).

2 Chronicles 13:13–19

When God's people turned to him, he helped them, even after their kingdom was disrupted. This gave hope to the original readers in similar situations.

2 Chronicles 13:19

The Lord gave Judah a miraculous victory. Abijah took the areas around Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron from Israel (2 Chronicles 13:19). Along with Zemaraim (2 Chronicles 13:4), these towns in the hill country on Judah's northern border formed a geographical unit (see Joshua 18:22–23). We do not know what happened to this territory later. By the time of Amos, which was around 760 BC, Bethel was a major pagan shrine in Israel.

2 Chronicles 13:20

Jeroboam lived longer than Abijah (see 1 Kings 15:9). The account of his death appears with his defeat, which was common for defeated warriors (see 2 Kings 19:37).

2 Chronicles 14:1

Asa ruled from 910 to 869 BC.

2 Chronicles 14:2–5

At the start of his reign, Asa removed the foreign altars in Judah (2 Chronicles 14:5). However, he did not remove the pagan shrines from Israel (2 Chronicles 15:17). These shrines were likely in the northern kingdom cities that Asa inherited from Abijah. Idolatry by other groups in the land troubled Judah throughout its history. This pagan activity might have increased again toward the end of Asa's reign, over thirty years later.

2 Chronicles 14:4

The phrase seek the LORD is the Chronicler's way of describing how to restore faith. It highlights and critiques Asa's reign (see 2 Chronicles 15:2, 12–13; 16:12).

2 Chronicles 14:7–14

- Solomon prayed for the Lord to hear his people when they went into battle (2 Chronicles 6:34). In the battle against Zerah, God answered this prayer.
- The term Cushite might refer to someone from southern Egypt (Nubia) or a Midianite area northeast of Aqabah (see Numbers 12:1; Habakkuk 3:7). However, several things suggest that Zerah was Egyptian:
- The mention of Libya in 2 Chronicles 16:8
- The battle's size (similar to Shishak's attack on Rehoboam in 2 Chronicles 12:3)
- Mareshah's location in western Judah suggest Zerah

He is otherwise unknown. He might have been a Nubian general sent by Osorkon I, the Libyan pharaoh

who ruled Egypt between the tenth and fourteenth years of Asa, around 900 to 897 BC. Another view is that Shishak created a buffer state around Gerar, supported by Nubian mercenaries who invaded Judah. The account, however, only states that Asa and his armies chased the enemy south to Gerar and took a large amount of plunder, especially from the herdsmen living in tents around the cities.

2 Chronicles 15:1–7

The prophet Azariah is not mentioned elsewhere. His speech to King Asa and the people of Judah also conveyed the Chronicler's message to the people of Judah after the exile in Babylon: The Lord will stay with his people, he will be found by those who seek him, and he will reward their obedience.

2 Chronicles 15:3–6

The dark times, caused by not knowing God (see Hosea 3:4–5), likely refer to the period of the judges.

2 Chronicles 15:5

there was no safety for travelers: Compare Judges 5:6–8 and Zechariah 8:10.

2 Chronicles 15:7

The call to be strong and courageous is a direct quote from what Moses and Joshua told Israel when they first entered the land (Deuteronomy 31:6–7; Joshua 1:6, 9, 18).

2 Chronicles 15:8

He captured towns in the hill country of Ephraim during his war with Baasha (2 Chronicles 16:1). Baasha and Asa were constantly at war (see 1 Kings 15:16).

2 Chronicles 15:8–18

The Chronicler described Asa's response using the prophet's exact words, but Asa's actions exceeded the general advice. When Asa heard the prophecy, he bravely started a wide-ranging reform. He began by removing the offensive idols that had returned to the land (see 2 Chronicles 14:5). Complete trust in God had won the war against the Cushites, and fully renewing the covenant brought peace to the promised land (2 Chronicles 15:15).

2 Chronicles 15:9

- those from the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh: The Chronicler always included the northern tribes in his accounts of spiritual reform (compare 2 Chronicles 30:1–11).
- The territory of Simeon became part of Judah.

2 Chronicles 15:10–15

The covenant renewal ceremony in the third month likely took place during the Festival of Harvest, also known as Pentecost. This major festival attracted large crowds to the temple from nearby areas. Disloyalty to the covenant was seen as treason and was punishable by death (Deuteronomy 17:2–7). The sacrifices were offerings dedicated from the victory over Zerah (2 Chronicles 14:15).

2 Chronicles 15:16

- The queen mother was the leading lady of the realm, usually holding the position for life. When she died, the title went to the mother of the next in line for the throne. There is no evidence that the queen mother had official duties, but she had significant influence.
- Asherah is well known from Canaanite stories as the wife of the god El and the mother of seventy children, including Baal. Her image likely had noticeable sexual features, which was common in Canaanite art.
- his grandmother: Literally his mother. The term "mother" can refer to any female ancestor. See 2 Chronicles 11:20, where Maacah is named as the mother of Abijah (Asa's father).

2 Chronicles 15:19

- no war: Most translations, like the New Living Translation, add "more" to help explain the likely meaning. If "no war" is the better reading, the thirty-fifth year might refer to the thirty-fifth year since the northern and southern kingdoms divided. This was around when Zerah the Ethiopian invaded Judah and Asa defeated him (2 Chronicles 14:9–15). But see the study note on 2 Chronicles 16:1.
- The Chronicler adds chronological notes to divide Asa's reign into periods that show the results of his decisions (see 2 Chronicles 14:1; 15:10; 16:1, 12, 13). The early battles with the north were considered unimportant for that time, although the Chronicler knew about them (see 2 Chronicles 15:8). Asa's early reign was marked by divine favor due to his obedience.

2 Chronicles 16:1

- In the thirty-sixth year of Asa's reign: The book of Kings states that King Baasha, who reigned from 909 to 886 BC, died in the twenty-sixth year of Asa's reign (1 Kings 16:8). One solution is that the Chronicles text might have errors and should instead read

the fifteenth and sixteenth years, which would be about 895 BC, instead of the thirty-fifth (2 Chronicles 15:19) and thirty-sixth years of Asa. Another possibility is that the Chronicler counted these years from the division of the kingdom.
- Ramah was located five miles north of Jerusalem near Geba and Mizpah (see 2 Chronicles 16:6). King Baasha expanded Israel deep into the territory of Benjamin, separating important territory from Judah shortly after Abijah's victories (2 Chronicles 13:19).

2 Chronicles 16:1–10

Asa relied on foreign powers instead of trusting the Lord when Baasha attacked. The Chronicler aimed to show that disobedience leads to consequences.

2 Chronicles 16:2

To stop Baasha's attacks, Asa bribed the Arameans with silver and gold from the temple. He reminded them of a treaty his father Abijah had made with them.

2 Chronicles 16:4

- King Ben-hadad of Aram (2 Chronicles 16:2) broke his treaty with Baasha and attacked northern Israel. He captured all of Naphtali, which included Galilee and most of the land north of the Jezreel Valley and east of the Sea of Galilee.
- Ijon was a large village in the southern Beqa' Valley, on the southern border of modern-day Lebanon. This town is usually listed with Dan (Laish), Abel-beth-maacah, and Hazor in northern Israel. Abel-beth-maacah was near a major waterfall of the Jordan River tributaries, at the meeting point of the Hula Valley and the Beqa' Valley in Lebanon.

2 Chronicles 16:6

Asa gathered workers to use materials from Ramah to strengthen his kingdom's northern border. Mizpah is often identified with Tell en-Nasba, about four miles north of Ramah and two miles from Bethel. Geba was likely located three miles beyond the watershed east of Gibeah, guarding a valley that leads to Jericho and the sanctuary at Gilgal.

2 Chronicles 16:7–9

Hanani the seer told Asa he would face war from then on because he disobeyed. This judgment contrasted with Asa's earlier victory over Zerah, when he trusted in the Lord despite the odds (2 Chronicles 14:9–13). Asa's earlier trust in the Lord brought peace to the land (2 Chronicles 14:5), but now his reliance on military power would lead to ongoing warfare.

2 Chronicles 16:10

Asa's unfaithfulness to the Lord by relying on power led to other sins, such as oppressing the prophet and the people.

2 Chronicles 16:12

People often viewed sickness as a punishment for sin (see 2 Chronicles 21:18–19; 26:20).

2 Chronicles 16:14

Asa received an honorable burial despite his sins. During his life, he made extravagant plans for his burial, including carving out his own tomb. Asa might have been imitating the pharaohs of Egypt with these preparations. The tradition of a large funeral fire is not mentioned outside of Chronicles and Jeremiah (compare Jeremiah 34:5).

2 Chronicles 17:1

Jehoshaphat reigned from 872 to 848 BC, including a two-year co-regency with his father, Asa. Asa's last years were marked by conflicts and oppression. Jehoshaphat needed to strengthen his rule in Judah to bring back peace and stability. During Asa's time, Israel was an enemy, but Jehoshaphat soon formed an alliance with Ahab (2 Chronicles 18:1–2).

2 Chronicles 17:3–4

For the first time, the Chronicler compares Judah's practices with those of northern Israel. He shows awareness that the Baal cult from Tyre had been introduced into northern worship (see 1 Kings 16:31–32).

2 Chronicles 17:5–6

The word translated as "gifts" is often translated as "tribute," like what conquering kings demanded from their subjects (for example, Judges 3:15–18). However, forced tribute is not the intended meaning here. The people of Judah willingly made Jehoshaphat very wealthy. Like Uzziah (2 Chronicles 26:16) and Hezekiah (32:25), wealth often leads to pride. However, Jehoshaphat was deeply committed to following the Lord's ways. He did not take pride in his own achievements; instead, his courage led him to remove idol worship from the kingdom. Jehoshaphat established control within his kingdom by practicing righteousness and faithfulness to God.

2 Chronicles 17:7–9

- Jehoshaphat fulfilled the Lord's command to teach the law (Deuteronomy 5:1; 17:18–20). He appointed five royal officers, nine Levites, and two priests to teach the people the book of the covenant. Levites often served as teachers during the Second temple period as well (Nehemiah 8:7).
- Some versions leave out Tob-adonijah; this seems to be a scribal error of repetition.

2 Chronicles 17:10–11

- The surrounding kingdoms feared the Lord, so they paid tribute to Jehoshaphat to buy peace. Peace often shows divine favor (see 2 Chronicles 14:2–6).
- The Arabs were likely desert tribes living south of Judah, near the Philistines.

2 Chronicles 17:12–19

Jehoshaphat was known for his international influence, construction projects, and strong army. Archaeologists have found highway forts in the Jordan Valley near the Dead Sea from his era. The reported number of troops in his army—over a million in Jerusalem—seems too high. Since leaders were organized by tribes (2 Chronicles 17:14), "thousand" (*'elep*) might mean "squad" or "platoon," which are smaller units. The totals might also include reserve divisions that rotated service (see 1 Chronicles 27:1–15). Jehoshaphat's troop numbers are about three times those of:

- Abijah (2 Chronicles 13:3)
- Asa (2 Chronicles 14:8)
- Amaziah (2 Chronicles 25:5)
- Uzziah (2 Chronicles 26:11–15)

They are similar to the number of warriors during David's census (1 Chronicles 21:5), when soldiers from the northern tribes were included. A large army showed God's blessing.

2 Chronicles 18:1–2

Jehoshaphat's alliance with Ahab led him to compromise his loyalty to the Lord (see 2 Chronicles 19:2–3; compare 2 Corinthians 6:14–18). His son Jehoram's marriage (2 Chronicles 21:1) to Ahab's daughter Athaliah (22:2) brought Israel's unfaithfulness into Judah (see 21:5–6, 12–13; 22:1–4).

2 Chronicles 18:5–7

The 400 prophets were Ahab's "yes-men." Jehoshaphat wanted to hear from a prophet of the Lord, but Ahab knew that such a prophet would disagree with his court prophets.

2 Chronicles 18:15

Ahab realized that Micaiah had not spoken God's word. Micaiah's answer used the same words as his rivals, or he might have spoken sarcastically (2 Chronicles 18:14).

2 Chronicles 18:18–22

The vision reveals how the false prophets deceived people, while it supports Micaiah's message. This deception ensured Ahab would lose in battle, as his judgment was decided.

2 Chronicles 18:25–26

Ahab shows defiance against the Lord by disrespecting Micaiah, the Lord's prophet.

2 Chronicles 18:28–34

Ahab knew he had gone against God's will and would face the consequences. However, he was more concerned about the Aramean army. He believed he could ignore God's judgment, showing his lack of respect for the Lord. This mistake proved fatal.

2 Chronicles 19:1–2

- Jehu was the son of Hanani, the prophet who had criticized Asa for relying on the Arameans (2 Chronicles 16:7–9). Jehu now scolded Jehoshaphat for his alliance with Ahab.
- The word love represents faithfulness to a covenant. Jehoshaphat's covenant with the wicked Ahab conflicted with his covenant with the Lord.

2 Chronicles 19:4–11

In Jehoshaphat's judicial reform, he appointed judges in the fortified towns (2 Chronicles 19:5) and a central court in Jerusalem (19:8). He urged all judges to think carefully and to judge with integrity and respect for the Lord. This meant they could not show favoritism or accept bribes, and they had to warn criminals not to sin against the Lord. The reform reinstated the law of Deuteronomy (Deuteronomy 16:18–17:13).

2 Chronicles 20:1

Meunites (see 1 Chronicles 4:41): The Meunites were a nomadic group living on the southern borders of Judah. Their name likely survives as the Arab town of Ma'an, located twelve miles southeast of Petra.

2 Chronicles 20:2

Translating the word as Edom instead of Aram aligns with the Chronicler's later description of the armies (2

Chronicles 20:10, 22–23) and the geographical description of the attack from the southeast through En-gedi. (Aram was northeast of Judah.)

2 Chronicles 20:3–12

Jehoshaphat reacted to the news of war with nearby nations by praying in sorrow, following Solomon's prayer ideals (2 Chronicles 6:24–40).

2 Chronicles 20:10

Mount Seir is another name for Edom (see Genesis 32:3 and the study note on Genesis 25:25).

2 Chronicles 20:14–17

After Jehoshaphat's lament, Jahaziel's announcement of rescue met the requirements for the speech a priest was to give before battle (Deuteronomy 20:2–4).

2 Chronicles 20:20–21

The appointed singers' song replaced the battle cry. The prophets were Jahaziel (2 Chronicles 20:14–17) and the Levitical musicians (20:21). Their musical praise during the battle march was a prophecy, declaring that God led the army.

2 Chronicles 20:32–33

The comparison of Jehoshaphat with Asa comes directly from 1 Kings 22:43 without any changes.

2 Chronicles 20:35–37

The Lord destroyed the fleet to stop Jehoshaphat's alliance with King Ahaziah of Israel from succeeding.

2 Chronicles 21:2–7

Jehoram, whose wife was Athaliah, the daughter of Ahab and Jezebel (2 Chronicles 18:1; 21:6; 22:2), was the first king from David's line to receive a completely negative evaluation. His murders (2 Chronicles 21:4) seriously threatened the dynasty's survival, which was only preserved because of the Lord's loyal faithfulness to David (21:7). On three other occasions, violence against the royal family nearly ended the dynasty (see 2 Chronicles 21:17; 22:8–9, 10–11).

2 Chronicles 21:5

Jehoram ruled from 848 to 841 BC after sharing the throne with his father for three years.

2 Chronicles 21:8–11

- Jehoram's disobedience led to the loss of what Asa and Jehoshaphat had achieved.
- Edom has been in rebellion: During Solomon's reign, controlling Edom allowed Israel to access rich Arabian trade. The Edomites had also rebelled before Solomon's death (1 Kings 11:14–22) and were likely not under Rehoboam's control. They seemed to come under Judah's control again after Jehoshaphat defeated them (2 Chronicles 20:1–30; compare 1 Kings 22:47).
- The town of Libnah was at the western end of the Valley of Elah, on the border of Philistine territory.

2 Chronicles 21:12–15

Elijah the prophet wrote a letter to Jehoram, warning him of punishment for his disobedience.

2 Chronicles 21:16–17

Jehoram could not stop the first revolts of Edom and Libnah (2 Chronicles 21:8–10). This weakness led to more attacks on Judah by the Philistines and the Arabs. The royal family was almost wiped out again.

2 Chronicles 21:18–20

Jehoram died after suffering from a long and painful bowel disease. He did not receive an honorary funeral rite (see 2 Chronicles 16:14) and was buried in disgrace, away from the royal cemetery.

2 Chronicles 22:2

one year: Ahaziah, also called Jehoahaz, ruled Judah briefly in 841 BC.

2 Chronicles 22:2–4

The queen mother, Athaliah, had a lot of influence over the king (see study note on 2 Chronicles 15:16). Athaliah was similar to her mother, Jezebel (see 2 Chronicles 22:10–23:15; compare 1 Kings 16:31–21:28), and she followed her grandfather Omri's example (see 1 Kings 16:21–26).

2 Chronicles 22:5–6

- Ramoth-gilead, a city for the Levites in the land of Gad (Joshua 21:38), was on a major trade route. It was important for both Aram and Israel.
- Jezreel, located at the base of Mount Gilboa in the Jezreel plain, became the summer residence of the Israelite kings.

2 Chronicles 22:7–9

Ahaziah died as a punishment for allying with the king of Israel. The king of Judah, who followed the advice of the Israelite house of Omri, shared their fate and found no safety when he died. Ahaziah's unfaithful-

ness nearly brought David's family line to the same end as Saul's, with no one left to take the throne.

2 Chronicles 22:10–12

Athaliah was not seen as a legitimate monarch. She did not receive the usual royal recognition of age or reign length like other rulers. She focused on eliminating potential male successors in Judah's royal family. Those who could not rule, like Ahaziah's sister, survived. Jehosheba, Ahaziah's half-sister, was the daughter of King Jehoram by a different wife than Athaliah. Athaliah ruled for six years, from 841 to 835 BC.

2 Chronicles 23:1–3

Jehoiada made an agreement with important military officers. They gained wide support from the Levites and clan leaders. The people's agreement with Joash was clear in Jehoiada's statement that the king's son must become king.

2 Chronicles 23:4–6

The best time for the coup was during the temple guard change. This was when many people moved around. One-third of the guards started their shifts. They were stationed in three places to do their usual tasks and to watch for any palace activity. The rest of the armed force stayed in the Lord's temple courtyards, forming a human wall to protect the king.

2 Chronicles 23:6–7

Only the priests and Levites on duty could enter the temple, so the Levites had to stop others from entering.

2 Chronicles 23:11

When Joash, who was seven years old, was anointed and crowned king, he received a copy of the law, as required by the law (see Deuteronomy 17:18–20).

2 Chronicles 23:16–17

The agreement included promises between the king and the people, between the Lord and the king, and between the Lord and the people. The promises with the Lord involved stopping the worship of Baal.

2 Chronicles 23:18–19

Jehoiada the priest helped Joash become king, restoring David's dynasty and bringing back temple worship as David instructed.

2 Chronicles 24:1

Joash ruled from 835 to 796 BC.

2 Chronicles 24:3

Jehoiada selected two wives for Joash, likely to ensure David's royal line had many descendants.

2 Chronicles 24:4–8

We do not know when Joash first tried to refurbish the temple. After failing to raise funds the first time, Joash called Jehoiada again in the twenty-third year of his reign (2 Kings 12:6). The priests might not have acted because they disagreed about who should fund and oversee the restoration. The king criticized Jehoiada for not acting and suggested a plan to make the offering more voluntary.

2 Chronicles 24:12–14

The book of Kings states that the money collected for repairing the temple was used only for wages (2 Kings 12:13–14). Chronicles adds that they used the money for temple artifacts only after finishing the repairs.

2 Chronicles 24:15–16

Living to 130 years shows that Jehoiada received a great blessing from the Lord. His royal burial as a priest-king also shows the people's great respect for him.

2 Chronicles 24:20–22

- Jehoiada carefully protected the Lord's temple courtyard from bloodshed and preserved David's dynasty. Ironically, Zechariah, his son, was murdered there by King Joash, whom Jehoiada had protected during the coup. Jesus mentioned this murder when criticizing religious leaders (Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:51).
- "May the LORD see this and call you to account": This prayer for vengeance was similar to those King David prayed against Saul's injustices (compare Psalms 5:10; 7:9; 9:19–20; 28:4; 56:7; 139:19; see also "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).

2 Chronicles 24:23–26

God could use war to judge Israel, just like any other nation. In a "holy war," a small force often defeated a much larger army.

2 Chronicles 24:25–26

Jehoiada received a royal burial (2 Chronicles 24:15–16), but Joash was buried without honor.

2 Chronicles 24:27

The Treatise of the Book of the Kings, which the Chronicler used as a source, is not available to us anymore (see also 2 Chronicles 9:29).

2 Chronicles 25:1

Amaziah reigned for twenty-nine years, from 796 to 767 BC. During this time, he shared the throne with his son Uzziah, starting in 792 BC.

2 Chronicles 25:2

but not wholeheartedly: See 2 Kings 14:3–4 for more details.

2 Chronicles 25:3–4

Amaziah executed the officials to avenge his father and fulfill the justice described in the Law.

2 Chronicles 25:5

Including Benjamin in this list of military officers shows that this tribe was part of the kingdom of Judah then.

2 Chronicles 25:6

Amaziah's army of 300,000 was smaller than Asa's 580,000 or Jehoshaphat's 1,160,000. This might explain why Amaziah wanted to hire more troops from Israel, the northern kingdom.

2 Chronicles 25:7–8

- The phrase a man of God referred to a prophet (as in Deuteronomy 33:1; 1 Samuel 2:27; 9:6–10; 1 Kings 13:1–31).
- The kingdom of Israel was politically foreign and spiritually unfaithful. Relying on Israel's troops for military strength would lead to spiritual compromise and God's opposition.

2 Chronicles 25:11

- The Valley of Salt, located south of the Dead Sea, was a frequent battlefield. David also fought the Edomites there (2 Samuel 8:13; see Psalm 60).
- Amaziah did not capture the port at Elath (2 Chronicles 26:2); his conquest was limited to northern Edom.

2 Chronicles 25:14–15

Conquerors sometimes worshiped the gods of a defeated nation, mistakenly thinking those gods helped them win. Amaziah shared this belief; he did not accept that the Lord is the only true God (see Isaiah 40:18–28; 42:8; Jeremiah 10:1–16).

2 Chronicles 25:20

Amaziah showed his pride by not seeking God. He overestimated his military strength after defeating Edom. His choice to fight Jehoash came from trusting other gods and ignoring God's judgment (see 2 Chronicles 18:9–34; 2 Thessalonians 2:11).

2 Chronicles 25:21

Beth-shemesh guarded the entrance to the Sorek Valley and Jerusalem's route to the coast. Jehoash might have wanted to block Jerusalem's trade or expand his own trade routes.

2 Chronicles 25:23

The Ephraim Gate was on the north side of the city, and the Corner Gate was on the west wall.

2 Chronicles 26:1–5

The Chronicler introduced Uzziah, also known as Azariah in Kings, twice (2 Chronicles 26:1–2, 3–5). He quoted two passages from Kings (2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:2–3).

2 Chronicles 26:3

Uzziah ruled for fifty-two years, from 792 to 740 BC. He shared power with his father, Amaziah, from 792 to 767 BC, and with his son Jotham from 750 to 740 BC.

2 Chronicles 26:6–8

These verses summarize Uzziah's international achievements. He conquered areas to the west, south, and southeast, but not to the north, where Jeroboam II's kingdom was strong (2 Kings 14:23–29). With God's guidance (2 Chronicles 26:7), Uzziah aimed to control the coastal highway and build towns in the conquered areas.

2 Chronicles 26:9–10

- Uzziah fixed the damage to Jerusalem's walls caused by Jehoash during his attack on Amaziah. Uzziah might have also repaired damage from the famous earthquake of his time (Amos 1:1; Zechariah 14:5). Towers and cisterns found in excavations at Qumran, Gibeah, Beersheba, and other sites date back to this period.
- Uzziah supported agriculture, which was crucial for an independent society.

2 Chronicles 26:11–14

Uzziah had a large and well-equipped army that helped him expand and defend his land. His name appears on a fragment of a text from Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria, which identifies Uzziah as the leader of an alliance.

2 Chronicles 26:16–18

Uzziah's leprosy was a punishment for breaking the covenant by burning incense in the temple. Only priests could do this (Exodus 30:7–9; Numbers 16).

2 Chronicles 26:21

Leprosy forced King Uzziah to spend his final years in quarantine in isolation (literally a free house). The meaning of this term is unclear; it often suggests he was free from royal duties. In Ugaritic texts, it appears to be a way to suggest a place of complete confinement.

2 Chronicles 27:1

Jotham became king after sharing the throne with his father, Uzziah, for eleven years, from 750 to 740 BC. He then ruled alone for five more years, from 740 to 735 BC, totaling sixteen years. Jotham lived at least four more years, as Hoshea rose to power in the northern kingdom in the twentieth year of Jotham son of Uzziah (2 Kings 15:30). However, Jotham's son, Ahaz, had already started ruling alongside him. After Jotham's sixteen official years, Ahaz took over as king (see study note on 2 Kings 16:1–2). Ahaz likely had his official accession ceremony after Jotham's death in 732 BC, so the author of 2 Chronicles counts Ahaz's official reign starting in 731 BC (see 2 Chronicles 28:1).

2 Chronicles 27:3–4

Jotham continued the restoration work started by his father, Uzziah. He built fortresses and towers in the forests. These served as lookouts and highway defenses within the kingdom and on the frontier.

2 Chronicles 27:5

Uzziah received tribute from the Ammonites (2 Chronicles 26:8), and Jotham continued to control their land east of the Jordan. These payments stopped after three years, possibly because Jotham was busy fighting Israel and Aram (2 Kings 15:37).

2 Chronicles 28:1

After ruling together with his father Jotham, Ahaz became king on his own. He reigned for sixteen years, from 731 to 715 BC.

2 Chronicles 28:3–4

Ahaz even sacrificed his own sons in the fire. He was copying the terrible actions of the Canaanites (see Deuteronomy 12:31; 18:9–10; Jeremiah 7:31; 19:5; 32:35).

2 Chronicles 28:9–10

you have slaughtered them: Although the Lord used Israel to punish Judah, the covenant forbade enslaving and murdering fellow Israelites (2 Chronicles 28:10; Leviticus 25:39–55).

2 Chronicles 28:11

- The Chronicler shows a positive attitude toward the north by using the term kinsmen (literally brothers).
- for the fierce anger of the LORD is upon you: Later, during Ahaz's reign, the kingdom of Israel would face destruction and exile in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:5–23).

2 Chronicles 28:16

Ahaz sent for help from the king of Assyria: See 2 Kings 16:7–9 for more details.

2 Chronicles 28:17–18

The Edomites and the Philistines were natural enemies of Judah. These armies captured towns along the Aijalon, Sorek, and Elah valleys. These areas were in the buffer zone of the foothills of Judah or the Negev.

2 Chronicles 28:22–23

King Ahaz rejected the Lord by building an altar like one in Damascus (2 Kings 16:10–16) and by offering sacrifices to the gods of Damascus.

2 Chronicles 28:24–25

Under King Ahaz, Judah hit its lowest spiritual point, similar to being in exile.

2 Chronicles 28:26

Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, fell to Assyria in 722 BC. This happened during the twenty-first year of Ahaz's reign in Judah (2 Kings 17:1–6). The Chronicler, who focuses on the southern kingdom, does not mention this event.

2 Chronicles 29:1

Hezekiah became king after ruling with his father, Ahaz. He reigned from 715 to 686 BC.

2 Chronicles 29:3–4

Hezekiah's first act as king was to repair the temple doors (2 Chronicles 29:3). The verb used (yekhazzeqem,

"he made them strong") is a pun on King Hezekiah's name (yekhizqiyyahu, "Yah makes strong"). This action set the stage for the king's speech to the priests and Levites (2 Chronicles 29:5–11).

2 Chronicles 29:5–11

Hezekiah's speech used words common during exile to describe the nation's failure. Like during Rehoboam's separation (2 Chronicles 12:1; see 13:10), the people were unfaithful when they abandoned the Lord.

2 Chronicles 29:12

Kohath, Merari, and Gershon were the three sons of Levi. Their descendants formed the three main clans of the Levite tribe (see Exodus 6:16).

2 Chronicles 29:12–36

To start sanctifying the temple, the Levites first sanctified themselves. They likely purified themselves by bringing offerings (see 2 Chronicles 30:15). Then they began to cleanse the temple. Two steps were needed to restore the temple:

1. Purification (removing pollution, 2 Chronicles 29:15–17)
2. Sanctification (rededicating the temple for holy worship, 2 Chronicles 29:20–36)

2 Chronicles 29:21

The bulls, rams, and lambs were for the burnt offering, and the male goats were for the sin offering (see Leviticus 1; 4:1–5:13).

2 Chronicles 29:31–36

- After purifying and rededicating the temple, people made individual offerings and sacrifices.
- The thanksgiving offerings were also known as praise offerings, peace offerings, or offerings of well-being (see Leviticus 3).

2 Chronicles 29:34

The Chronicler feels surprised and delighted by the people's spontaneous actions and the large number of praise offerings during the thanksgiving festivities. These events show that the Lord prepared the people's hearts for the occasion, exceeding the expectations of the priests and Levites.

2 Chronicles 30:1–27

This story of Hezekiah's Passover celebration shows the Chronicler's focus on Israel's unity, the people's spiritual readiness, and the success of following Solomon's restoration plan at the temple dedication (2 Chronicles 7:14).

2 Chronicles 30:2–3

A month later than usual, the law allowed for a delayed Passover if someone was ceremonially unclean or on a long journey (Numbers 9:9–11). Hezekiah's Passover followed the spirit, if not the exact rules, of these provisions. The delayed Passover offered a chance for national unity and spiritual renewal.

2 Chronicles 30:5

Hezekiah sent messengers from Beersheba to Dan, which traditionally represents the whole nation, including the now-empty lands of Israel's northern tribes.

2 Chronicles 30:9–11

The Assyrians conquered the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:5–28), and many people were exiled to Assyria. People from other conquered lands moved there. Most of these foreigners, along with the Israelites left by the Assyrians, saw Israel's defeat as proof that the Lord, the God of Israel, was powerless. They mocked the idea of traveling to Jerusalem to honor him.

2 Chronicles 30:11

Some people humbled themselves, meeting the first requirement in Solomon's formula (2 Chronicles 7:14).

2 Chronicles 30:14

Hezekiah faced several challenges before observing Passover. Although the temple was purified, the city was not. The gathered crowd's first task was to remove all pagan altars. They disposed of them in the Kidron Valley, where they could be burned.

2 Chronicles 30:15

The priests were not ready for the large crowd. The issue might have been with priests from outside the city who missed the earlier purification. However, the people's response was better than that of the professional clerics, which was embarrassing for the clerics.

2 Chronicles 30:17–19

Many pilgrims traveled far from other countries and could not undergo the purification ceremonies. They were not ready to join the ceremony. Hezekiah let them eat the Passover without the sacrificial ritual, even though they were impure. He prayed for God to accept their worship. Hezekiah followed the restoration process (see 2 Chronicles 7:14).

2 Chronicles 30:20

- God's response to Hezekiah's prayer showed that he cares more about the heart's attitude than strict ritual details.
- healed the people: Compare 2 Chronicles:14.

2 Chronicles 30:25

In this joyful celebration, everyone felt included, and those who were apart came together again.

2 Chronicles 30:26

No celebration like this had happened since Solomon's time. Hezekiah set up conditions for covenant faithfulness like those during David and Solomon's era.

2 Chronicles 31:1

After purifying and rededicating the temple, the city of Jerusalem, and its people, Hezekiah started the third stage of his reform. He removed pagan worship objects from all of Judah and the northern territories.

2 Chronicles 31:3–10

Both the king and his people provided supplies for the temple. Israel came together to support the temple, and their response exceeded expectations and needs.

2 Chronicles 31:6

The large piles of animal tithes might refer to the money from selling animals, not the animals themselves. The law allowed people to exchange their field's produce for money (Deuteronomy 14:24–26) and to eat the meat at home (Deuteronomy 12:15).

2 Chronicles 31:10

The people's great generosity reminds us of when they first built the tabernacle (Exodus 36:3–5).

2 Chronicles 31:14–19

Many Levites, mostly from small towns, could serve. Small groups traveled to Jerusalem in shifts for short periods (see 1 Chronicles 24:1–19). All Levites received shares of the offerings given at the temple.

2 Chronicles 32:1–23

The Chronicler summarizes the long account of the siege against Jerusalem in twenty-three verses (compare 2 Kings 18:17–19:37; Isaiah 36–38). God responded to King Sennacherib of Assyria's attack by blessing Judah and Hezekiah for their faithfulness in seeking the Lord.

2 Chronicles 32:3–5

Sennacherib's attack was not a surprise; Hezekiah provoked it by breaking a treaty (2 Kings 18:7, 20). Water was crucial for both attackers and defenders during sieges. Hezekiah ensured Sennacherib's army could not access the city's water supply. In a famous ancient engineering feat, Hezekiah's tunnel connected the fresh waters of the Gihon Spring to the Pool of Siloam, providing water within the city walls. This tunnel is almost 530 meters long (about 580 yards or one-third of a mile) and about two meters (six feet) high. The Hezekiah inscription, found in the tunnel in 1880, describes how the excavators met to connect the two ends. Although much of the tunnel used natural underground aqueducts, it was a brilliant strategy to protect the city's citizens.

2 Chronicles 32:10–19

The Assyrian king's threats highlighted the main issues for the people of Jerusalem. The real question was whether to trust in God. The enemy king claimed Hezekiah could not be trusted (2 Chronicles 32:11–12) because he had angered the Lord by removing God's shrines and altars. However, the opposite was true. This reform was Hezekiah's greatest act of loyalty to the Lord. The question was whether God could be trusted against Assyria's power (2 Chronicles 32:11–15).

2 Chronicles 32:21

The fate of Sennacherib is similar to the story in the Book of Kings (see 2 Kings 19:35–37).

2 Chronicles 32:22–23

The Chronicler concludes the story by showing that Assyria's disaster led to peace in Judah. Both the Lord and Hezekiah gained respect from other nations.

2 Chronicles 32:26

Hezekiah and the people's sincere repentance pleased God, so the Lord did not show anger during Hezekiah's lifetime.

2 Chronicles 32:27–30

Hezekiah's wealth made him a king similar to Solomon.

2 Chronicles 32:31

The visit by the Babylonian envoys is described in more detail in 2 Kings 20:12–20. The Chronicler explains God's reasons for that visit.

2 Chronicles 33:1–20

Manasseh ruled for fifty-five years, from 697 to 642 BC, longer than any other king in Judah. His reign included a period when he ruled with his father, Hezekiah, from 697 to 686 BC. A long reign often indicated blessing, even though Manasseh did evil in the Lord's sight. The Chronicler describes his humiliation, repentance, and the restoration of worship in Judah.

2 Chronicles 33:7

The carved idol represented Asherah (see 2 Kings 21:7).

2 Chronicles 33:11

A nose ring caused both pain and total humiliation. Assyrian records describe this treatment of their prisoners.

2 Chronicles 33:12

Manasseh's response met the requirements of Solomon's prayer during the temple's dedication (2 Chronicles 7:14).

2 Chronicles 33:12–17

The book of Kings does not mention Manasseh's repentance. It only tells of the promised judgment due to his wicked deeds (see 2 Kings 21:10–16). Chronicles describes the good things he did after repenting, following his father Hezekiah's example. However, Manasseh's actions could not turn the people's hearts back to the Lord or stop God's judgment on Judah (2 Chronicles 33:17).

2 Chronicles 33:13

Manasseh's experience was a small version of what the nation would face: exile and captivity due to turning away from God, followed by repentance and returning to the Lord.

2 Chronicles 33:14–17

Manasseh might have been fixing the walls when he was captured. His religious reforms were like Hezekiah's but not finished. Later, Josiah removed the temple altars that Manasseh had built (2 Kings 23:12).

2 Chronicles 33:18

The Chronicles of the Kings of Israel is a record that is no longer available.

2 Chronicles 33:19

the Records of the Seers: This document is no longer available.

2 Chronicles 33:21

Amon ruled for a short time from 642 to 640 BC.

2 Chronicles 33:24

The text does not specify the political forces behind Amon's assassination. However, Egypt might have instigated it when Assyria's power weakened, creating an opportunity.

2 Chronicles 34:1

Josiah ruled for thirty-one years, from 640 to 609 BC.

2 Chronicles 34:3

When Josiah was sixteen, he started to seek the God of his ancestor David. At twenty, he began his own reforms.

2 Chronicles 34:6

By Josiah's twelfth year as king, in 628 BC, the Assyrian Empire had mostly fallen apart. During this time, northern Israel was almost empty. This allowed Josiah to expand his influence and control into Manasseh, Ephraim, and Simeon, reaching even as far as Naphtali.

2 Chronicles 34:12–13

The fact that musicians supervised the construction shows the importance of Levites leading this work. Other ancient texts mention that music was often part of construction projects.

2 Chronicles 34:14–18

- Finding the Book of the Law of the LORD was a reward for being faithful.
- The book, likely written by Moses, was probably Deuteronomy. It may have been forgotten and lost during the unfaithful times of Manasseh or Amon.

2 Chronicles 34:24

the curses written in the book: See Deuteronomy 27:14–26; 28:15–68. Curses in a covenant explain what happens to those who break the covenant, as Israel and Judah did with the Lord. These curses included exile.

2 Chronicles 34:27–28

King Josiah did not die peacefully; Pharaoh Neco II of Egypt killed him (2 Chronicles 35:20–25). However, Josiah was buried peacefully, meaning Jerusalem was at peace, and exile did not occur during his reign. His repentant spirit prevented immediate disaster.

2 Chronicles 34:29–32

Renewing the covenant was the most important event in Josiah's reform.

2 Chronicles 35:3

The holy ark might have been taken from the temple during the unfaithfulness of Manasseh or Amon.

2 Chronicles 35:4–6

The priests and Levites followed the instructions of David and Solomon (2 Chronicles 8:14–15; 1 Chronicles 24–26). Usually, the person offering the Passover animal would slaughter it (Deuteronomy 16:5–6). However, because the offerers did not have time to purify themselves, Josiah continued Hezekiah's practice of having the Levites slaughter the Passover animals (see 2 Chronicles 30:13–20). During Josiah's time, the large number of participants might have also caused logistical problems.

2 Chronicles 35:7–9

The Passover sacrifice required lambs and young goats (Exodus 12:21). The cattle were an extra offering. The totals Josiah provided, along with others' contributions, were nearly double those in Hezekiah's time (see 2 Chronicles 30:24). However, they were less than the offerings at the temple dedication (see 2 Chronicles 7:5).

2 Chronicles 35:13

The Levites quickly brought out the food, following the need for speed required during Passover (Exodus 12:11).

2 Chronicles 35:18

This Passover had more participants than the one Hezekiah observed. During this Passover, the priests and Levites played an important role, as Josiah specifically required (2 Chronicles 35:15–16; compare 30:3, 15).

2 Chronicles 35:20–24

The story skips from Josiah's eighteenth year in 622 BC to the year he died in 609 BC. As the Assyrian Empire weakened, Egypt and Babylon, once under Assyrian control, clashed. King Neco of Egypt, who had allied with Assyria to resist Babylon's growth, asked Josiah to let his army pass freely. Josiah's decision to block them might have been due to an alliance with Babylon or his own effort to gain independence from Egypt. Josiah died because he ignored a divine message given by a non-Jewish king.

2 Chronicles 35:25

Jeremiah respected Josiah greatly (see Jeremiah 22:15–16; compare Jeremiah 22:10). The Book of Laments was lost and is not the same as the Book of Lamentations.

2 Chronicles 36:1–4

Jehoahaz, also known as Shallum (see Jeremiah 22:11), was not Josiah's oldest son (1 Chronicles 3:15). The reason he was chosen as king is not explained. Pharaoh Neco quickly intervened, placing Jehoahaz's older brother Eliakim in his place and renaming him Jehoiakim.

2 Chronicles 36:2

Jehoahaz ruled for three months in 609 BC.

2 Chronicles 36:5

- Jehoiakim ruled from 609 to 598 BC.
- he did evil: Jeremiah described his reign as focused on self-promotion and injustice (Jeremiah 22:13–17).

2 Chronicles 36:9–10

- The Chronicler focuses on Jehoiachin's brief reign by mentioning his exile and the tribute paid from the temple instruments. The Babylonian Chronicle describes Jehoiachin's capture: "In the seventh year of Nebuchadnezzar, during the month of Kislev, the king of Akkad gathered his troops, marched to the land west of the Jordan, and set up camp against the city of Judah. On the second day of the month of Adar, he seized the city and captured the king." Jehoiachin was taken captive on March 16, 597 BC and brought to Babylon about a month later.
- Jehoiachin remained a captive in Babylon for thirty-seven years (see 2 Kings 25:27; Jeremiah 52:31).

2 Chronicles 36:11

Zedekiah was king from 597 to 586 BC.

2 Chronicles 36:11–14

Jeremiah repeatedly advised Zedekiah to surrender to the Babylonians instead of seeking help from Egypt (Jeremiah 25:1–11; 27:1–22; 34:1–22; 37:1–38:28). However, Zedekiah refused to humble himself and rebelled, breaking his oath.

2 Chronicles 36:13

swear by God: The vassal oath given to him was likely similar to those from Assyrian treaties, sworn in the name of the vassal's god.

2 Chronicles 36:19

The temple was destroyed in August 586 BC (see 2 Kings 25:8; Jeremiah 52:12).

2 Chronicles 36:21

- Jeremiah predicted the length of the captivity (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10; see study note on Ezra 6:15).
- the land enjoyed its Sabbath rest: See Leviticus 26:34–35, 43, where exile is the punishment for disobedience; the land is left unused for all the missed Sabbaths. The land's rest also prepared it for restoration.

2 Chronicles 36:22–23

Chronicles ends with verses that introduce the book of Ezra. King Cyrus of Persia allowed the people of Judah to have a new exodus, as the prophet Isaiah announced (Isaiah 40:1–11).